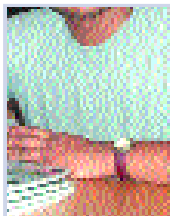


insight ■ netreturns



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“My work involves a lot of research and I use blogs to find relevant and reliable information on a particular topic at one location.”

restrained by industry or social pressures.

Blogs can be completely personal, that is, the writer may not allow anyone to see what's on it, but this is not the idea of the Internet. One of the primary reasons why material is published on the Net is the unhindered wide audience it automatically offers. However, a person can dictate what appears on his or her blog and what doesn't. This increases the respect and trust a blogger gains because unlike forums, though the blogger allows others to post messages on the blog, it is still his or her personal space. No blogger would allow any violation of this personal space even though he or she may try hard to get together the ideas of several people to get as open an opinion or as real a truth as possible.

Blogging can also be used as a means of direct communication with your peers, building a thread of conversation and an ever-valuable archive of intelligence. Omar Javaid, Chief Technology Officer and founder of the mobile-computing consulting firm, Mobilocity, used to regularly e-mail interesting URLs to colleagues and clients. Now he just maintains a Web log, which he updates frequently.

Window shopping

There are several free blogs on the Net. One of the most popular is LiveJournal



LiveJournal is one of the most popular blogging sites, offering excellent features for amateur and seasoned bloggers

(www.livejournal.com).

In fact, the site has become so popular that the developers have put up restrictions for signing up. If you have a friend who's already blogging on it, he or she can invite you to join LiveJournal for free, otherwise you

will have to blog at a price. LiveJournal, like many other sites, takes blogging very seriously and provides excellent security features so that bloggers can freely discuss whatever they want to, without worrying about intruders. LiveJournal is open source and has been used as a base by many Web sites to provide free blogging services.

At LiveJournal, you can configure your account so that you have complete control over the content posted in your space. You can choose to display your contact information, location and birthday with your blogs, and whether everyone can view it or only the users listed in your Friends list. As a measure against spam-robots, which harvest e-mail addresses from Web sites, LiveJournal can display your e-mail address differently, so that it is not recognised by such software. Whether your space is indexed by search engines or not can also be controlled by you. You may even choose to hide your Friends list from your online profile with the site.

To ensure high quality of content on your blog, you can enable or disable various restrictions. You can choose to disable message boards completely, which means that no one can post any replies to your posts. You can allow anyone, only users registered with LiveJournal or only users from your Friends list to post messages on your blog. The service can optionally log IP addresses of people who post messages. This can sometimes be useful in determining whether the message was actually posted by that person, especially with the growing number of cable Internet connections, where a lot of computers have static IP addresses.

Being open source, LiveJournal gives you complete access to the code. Thus, advanced bloggers can simply understand the LiveJournal structure and take better control of their blogs. For example, you can override the stylesheet your blog uses by modifying the header information or

Blogging Etiquette

Blogging is a form of communication publishing on the Internet. It involves several communities, from various walks of life so it's wise to follow a few guidelines so that you don't end up offending anyone.

- Don't use abusive language on public blogs. Though it may be common among your friends and peers, there could be several others reading your blog. An alternative is to keep your blog completely private, allowing only friends to read it.
- Be discrete with the pictures and don't use revealing ones—they might offend even friends.
- Respect all bloggers. Be polite when you post comments on someone else's blogs, be it in tune with or against what they have posted. Blogging is no different from conversation. Don't say anything on your blog that you wouldn't say to a friend.
- Healthy blogging is for the open-minded. Don't ban a user because he or she has a differing opinion. Opinions should be welcomed, or disabled completely.
- Don't hesitate to ban mischief-makers from your blog. You will be doing a disservice to your fellow-bloggers.
- If you are referencing items from other Web sites, provide a link to them. This not only helps readers, but also tremendously increases the credibility of your blog. Also, remember to give due credit to the original source of content, be it articles or quotes.

even help towards the development of the service.

Another service, Blogger (www.blogger.com), has an impressive Web logging interface, ideal for those who don't want



Blogger is a simple, no-frills site, where you post your thoughts, opinions, ideas and happenings of the day